



Sharing stories: 'I always make it a point to speak to as many people as I can in the warm-up area — not because I'm overly social, but because I'm curious. I like to know what people are up to, and honestly, I enjoy a little masala'. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

was delayed. Then I saw a crowd, medical personnel, stretchers. Heard whispers.

Yuma had fallen.

The reigning champ. who was second in the standings — breathing down my neck.

For a second, I thought I had gold locked. But I knew better. Without Yuma, silver was a realistic goal. If everything went right, maybe even gold.

As I was getting ready for my race, I saw him come out, neck-brace on. Concussed. Walking out, *ready to run hurdles*.

I couldn't believe it. This event is hard *with* full senses. He was about to do it while concussed.

I put the focus back on me.

Ran a near-perfect race — **14.58** — and extended my lead. Yuma? 14.53.

Next up was discus.

Now this one — this one always gets to me. My relationship with the discus is like that of two old friends who respect each other but rarely get along. I've worked on it, I've refined my technique, I've visualised it a hundred times — but still, every time I step into that ring, I'm not quite sure which version of me is going to show up.

I wasn't expecting miracles. I just needed to hold my ground. My

warm-up throws were decent — not amazing, but enough to give me hope. My first attempt went out to 36. Second attempt — a bit more aggressive — landed around 37. I knew it was safe, not a PR, but enough. Enough to move on.

Then came pole vault — the monster in my story.

The event I had dreaded the most. I had been training, working on my run-up, on getting more consistent, but let's face it — it's still a relatively weak event for me. Especially when you're trying to survive among men who are clearing 4.70–4.90m on autopilot.

I opened low at 3.80m and cleared it easily. That gave me a little boost. Then 3.90m — again, clean. I tried 4.00m to see if I could sneak in a little buffer but missed all three. Still, I was still very much in contention. The medal equation was now real.

At this point, it wasn't just about competing. It was about surviving with enough juice left for **javelin and the 1500m**.

Now going into javelin, we had five guys fighting for three medals, and I was sitting in third. Still, I believed I could win gold. I was feeling great — javelin had been coming along well in training, and I knew I had one of the strongest 1500m races in the field.

Remember how shot put went? Two bad throws and then one big heave that changed everything? Javelin was the exact opposite.

My first throw — as soon as it left my arm — I *knew* it was a personal best. It landed cleanly around 56 or 57 meters. I pumped my fist... but the joy was short-lived. I had barely — *just barely* — stepped over the foul line. It wouldn't count.

Now I had two throws left, and my best throw wasn't measured.

The second throw was more conservative, more controlled — it only went 50 meters. And suddenly, I wasn't just thinking about gold slipping away. I was staring at the possibility of finishing outside the medals altogether. The other guys chasing the podium had strong throws lined up.

My third and final throw: 51 meters. Not enough.

It would all come down to the 1500m.

By the time a decathlete reaches the final event, you're running on fumes. Forty-eight hours of emotional highs and lows, two sleepless nights, your body wrecked. At that point, it's not about fitness — it's about grit. It's about willpower.

We were all in the combined events area waiting for the 1500m,